Chapter 9

Resolving Conflicts and Preventing Violence

1. Causes of Conflict
2. Resolving Conflicts
3. Understanding Violence
4. Preventing and Overcoming Abuse

Lesson 1 — Causes of Conflict

Understanding Conflicts

A **conflict** is any disagreement, struggle, or fight. Conflicts are a completely normal part of life — because people are different, they will inevitably clash sometimes. The key is learning to manage them before they get out of hand. When handled well, conflicts can actually strengthen relationships.

Common Causes

Misunderstandings	Two people interpret the same thing differently — especially common across different backgrounds, cultures, or age groups
Power struggles	Disagreements over who gets to make decisions or set rules
Jealousy or envy	Tension when someone feels left behind or replaced
Property disputes	Arguments over borrowed belongings
Conflicting values	Differences in beliefs about how people should act
Lack of respect	Rudeness, prejudice, or treating someone as less than equal

The emotions most likely to cause a conflict to ESCALATE — become more serious — are hurt pride, embarrassment, and the desire for revenge. Recognizing these feelings in yourself is one of the most important skills in preventing violence.

Lesson 2 — Resolving Conflicts

Negotiation

Negotiation — using communication and compromise to find a mutually acceptable solution — is the core skill for resolving conflict.

1	**Calm down first** Take time before starting — never negotiate when emotions are running too hot to think clearly
2	**Each side explains their view** Use 'I' messages and active listening — no interrupting
3	**Ask clarifying questions** Make sure both sides actually understand each other
4	**Brainstorm solutions together** Generate options without judging them yet
5	**Discuss pros and cons** Evaluate the options together
6	**Agree on a solution** Aim for win-win — or the best compromise available
7	**Follow up** Check in later to see if the solution actually worked

Mediation and Peer Mediation

When negotiation alone isn't enough, **mediation** — bringing in a neutral third party — can break the deadlock. Many schools have **peer mediation** programs where trained students help classmates resolve conflicts peacefully. The three keys: neutrality, confidentiality, and clear ground rules. Note: Peer mediation is NOT appropriate for situations involving violence, weapons, or criminal behavior — those require school administration or law enforcement.

Lesson 3 — Understanding Violence

Violence is the threatened or actual use of physical force to harm another person or damage property. Contributing factors include uncontrolled anger, need to control others, prejudice, and the desire for revenge. Alcohol and drugs are directly linked — they lower inhibitions and impair judgment.

Firearm Violence

Guns are currently the LEADING CAUSE OF DEATH among children and teens ages 1–17 in the U.S. — surpassing car accidents. Teens who carry guns are significantly more likely to become victims of gun violence themselves. Do NOT carry a weapon. If guns are in your home, they should be stored unloaded in a locked cabinet with a trigger lock.

Types of Violence

Assault	An unlawful physical attack or threat of attack. Roughly half occur between people who know each other.
School shootings	A major reality for students across the U.S. Know your school's emergency procedures. Report threats — even ones that seem like jokes. Taking threats seriously saves lives.
Sexual violence	Any unwelcome sexual contact. Most victims are under 18. Resources: RAINN Hotline 1-800-656-4673 (24/7, free, confidential).
Hate crimes	Crimes motivated by hatred toward a group — race, religion, sexual orientation, disability, or other characteristics.

Lesson 4 — Preventing and Overcoming Abuse

Warning Signs of an Abusive Relationship

- Pressures you into sexual activity
- Tries to make the relationship serious or exclusive very quickly
- Acts jealous or possessive — tries to control where you go or who you see
- Yells, swears, or emotionally attacks you
- Threatens physical violence

> Controlling behavior is NOT love. These are warning signs of an abusive relationship — not signs of caring or devotion.

Forms of Abuse

Physical	Intentionally causing bodily harm — hitting, kicking, shoving, biting, throwing objects
Emotional	Attacking someone's sense of worth through verbal abuse, humiliation, threats, or isolation
Sexual	Any pattern of unwanted sexual contact or pressure
Stalking	Repeatedly following, harassing, or threatening someone — in person or digitally through texts, emails, and social media monitoring

Date Rape

About **1 in 9 high school girls** reports experiencing sexual violence by a dating partner. Alcohol is a major factor — some perpetrators also use date rape drugs (Rohypnol, GHB, ketamine). Never leave your drink unattended; if your drink smells or tastes strange, don't finish it.

> RAINN National Sexual Assault Hotline: 1-800-656-4673 (24/7, free, confidential). Survivors deserve support, not shame. The abuse was never their fault.

Chapter Vocabulary

Lesson 1

Conflict	Any disagreement, struggle, or fight
Interpersonal conflicts	Conflicts between two or more people or groups
Escalate	To become more serious or intense

Lesson 2

Negotiation	The use of communication and compromise to settle a disagreement
Mediation	Bringing in a neutral third party to help others resolve their conflicts peacefully
Confidentiality	Respecting the privacy of both parties and keeping details of a discussion secret
Peer mediation	A process in which specially trained students help other students resolve conflicts peacefully

Lesson 3

Violence	The threatened or actual use of physical force or power to harm another person or damage property
Assault	An unlawful physical attack or threat of attack
Random violence	Violence committed for no particular reason against an unrelated victim
Homicide	The willful killing of one human being by another
Sexual violence	Any form of unwelcome sexual contact directed at an individual
Sexual assault	Any intentional sexual attack against another person
Rape	Any form of sexual intercourse that takes place against a person's will

Lesson 4

Physical abuse	A pattern of intentionally causing bodily harm or injury to another person
Emotional abuse	A pattern of attacking another person's emotional development and sense of worth
Verbal abuse	The use of words to mistreat or injure another person; a form of emotional abuse
Sexual abuse	A pattern of sexual contact forced upon a person against their will
Stalking	Repeatedly following, harassing, or threatening an individual in person or online
Date rape	When one person in a dating relationship forces the other into sexual intercourse